THE SHE LIST

EDUCATION & SOCIAL WORK

Green Crusader



RAJWANT RAWAT

Sunita Narain, *62*
Director General, Centre for Science & Environment, and Editor, **Down to Earth**

SUNITA NARAIN WAS AMONG the 31 experts appointed by the UAE government to the advisory board for the United Nations Climate Change Conference, or COP28, that culminated on December 12. As usual, she was not there just to peddle empty do-goodism.

A month before the climate summit, she and her colleagues at the fortnightly magazine *Down To Earth* and the Centre for Science and Environment (CSE) had published an investigative report on how private sector finance in the voluntary carbon market is benefiting neither the planet nor the people. The report found that the current carbon markets could end up increasing global emissions. "At COP28, our report played a key role in bringing out the importance of integrity, transparency and benefit-sharing of private finance in the voluntary carbon market," says Sunita.

Equitability and integrity have been the two cornerstones of Sunita's environmental activism, which is opposed to elite conservationism. She believes that the poor co-exist with nature and the rich need to learn from them to build a common future. From the time she co-edited the first 'State of India's Environment Report' in 1985, Sunita has been advocating for local democracy to protect the environment and chalk out a path for sustainable development.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Has played a critical role in pushing governments across the globe to walk the talk on environmental issues

Being a woman in her profession has both advantages and downsides. As a woman, she can think out of the box but is often boxed in by her peers, who are mostly men. "They don't want to rock the boat and that leaves me alone taking the path untrodden," says Sunita, who at the age of 17 joined the student anti-logging activist group Kalpavriksh.

The courage and conviction to follow her passion came from mother Usha Narain, who single-handedly brought up four daughters.

For Sunita, the journey that she embarked on as a teenager has been a long and slow one but, gradually, she has witnessed some positive changes in the consciousness and perspectives of policymakers and other stakeholders. A lot of things that she and her colleagues have been talking about have ended up guiding government policies. However, what hurts her the most is the severity of air pollution in Delhi, the city where she was born and has worked all her life. "We are not ready to make tough decisions for clean air," she says. "Tough decisions don't mean inconveniencing people but finding ways to lessen the pain caused by such decisions. It has to be transformational and fast." ■

–Kaushik Deka

THE TRAILBLAZER

"They (male peers) don't want to rock the boat and that leaves me alone taking the path untrodden"

↘ ORGANIC LIVING Sunita is extremely proud of the kitchen garden in her Delhi home, where she grows all her vegetables and a variety of fruits too

↘ SCREEN TIME Actor Leonardo DiCaprio interviewed her in 2016 for his documentary *Before the Flood*

↘ BEHIND THE SCENES She has set a rule that *Down to Earth*, the magazine she edits, cannot publish her photo